

Fake news

While rumour and sensational reports are nothing new, the world wide web has accelerated the spread of what is commonly called “fake news”. The term itself has become common currency, with many people using it indiscriminately to label things they don’t like or agree with. In its original sense, the term means a news report or article that is not based on researched fact, but passed off as if it is. “Fake news” is often spread by people who want to exploit people’s ignorance in order to build up a certain perception of something or someone.

Spotting “fake news”:

- Check sources: who is reporting the information? Are they reliable?
- Is the story being reported elsewhere?
- Does it seem too sensational to be true?
- Can the sources be checked?
- Does the person or company stand to gain something from the information presented?

REAL WORLD

Illegal content

Just about anything can be posted online, and even some highly illegal content can end up on popular sites such as YouTube and Facebook. If you have seen something that you feel is scary, upsetting, or worrying, speak to an adult about it. They may be able to explain it, or configure your internet browser or search engine so that adult content is filtered out. If it is more serious, an adult can help you report it. Reporting can be done to the site itself, or if you suspect that a law may have been broken, to the police. There are also places online and possibly in school that can help children who are traumatized by online content.



Emotional upset

The internet can be a negative place, which can upset some people. It could be because they were criticized, or people didn’t respond to them in a way they wanted, or they saw something upsetting.



Protect yourself

Knowing this means you do not need to take aggressive, abusive, or provocative comments to heart. It is better to report them and avoid those sites in future if the situation doesn’t improve.



Passive use

Using technology when bored or distracted is an example of passive use of digital devices. It can also distract others when engaged in a group activity, such as sharing a meal or watching a movie.



Active use

The best way to use digital devices is to use them actively: before you start, have a definite task you are looking to achieve, and when it is finished, put the device away.



Instant gratification

The instant, at-your-fingertips accessibility of the world wide web has led to people expecting to be entertained all of the time. With information, speed tends to be more valued than accuracy.



Take your time

Knee-jerk reactions are often inaccurate and over-simplified. It takes time to understand a complex idea, or to see someone else’s point of view, but in doing so, you may learn a lot more.